

Epstein Islands and other violent crime recreations on Roblox

Key Insights

- An exploratory study of user-generated violent crime recreations on Roblox, conducted in April 2026, found Roblox has hosted avatars, digital environments, and role-play activities themed around real-world violent and sexual crimes including:
 - Jeffrey Epstein's child sexual exploitation and trafficking network;
 - Sean 'Diddy' Combs's sexual abuse allegations;
 - The assassination of Charlie Kirk;
 - Mass shootings; and
 - Violent deportation raids.
- Roblox formally prohibit this type of content under its community standards, however, virtual world crime recreations appear to be part of a recurring pattern of online content that is not fully addressed by existing moderation systems.
- The social and psychological impacts of engaging with virtual representations of real-world violent and sexual crimes remain poorly understood, particularly for children.
- For Roblox, this is a significant concern given the platform's young user base, including an estimated 1.7 million child users in Australia.

Evidence & Analysis

Roblox is one of the world's largest digital platforms, with an average of 151 million daily active users. It is particularly popular among young people: 56% of users are under the age of 17, and 40% are under 13.[1] Young users engage with Roblox to play games, socialise, and participate in online communities.

The platform primarily operates as a user-generated content ecosystem in which third parties create and publish games and environments (both known as "experiences"), avatars, and other digital assets. These can be developed using a free tool, Roblox Studio, which enables users to build, script, and publish content on the platform. This user-generated content is produced by a diverse range of creators, including everyday users, hobbyists, and professional game development studios.

In 2024, the presence of crime recreations on the platform received mainstream media attention following an investigative report by Hindenburg Research. The report identified hundreds of game environments referencing Jeffrey Epstein and Sean "Diddy" Combs, many of which were accessible within spaces frequented by younger users. Examples included games titled *Escape to Epstein Island* and *Run from Diddy Simulator*, as well as usernames such as "JeffEpsteinSupporter".

We identified avatars styled to resemble Jeffrey Epstein and Charlie Kirk; along with user reports of an avatar modelled on the perpetrator of the Sandy Hook Elementary School. We also found evidence of a live roleplaying event hosted on Roblox between February and March 2026 themed around Jeffrey Epstein, allegedly including simulated trafficking scenarios and "auction"-style interactions.

Roblox acts to moderate and remove content that violates its community standards. For content depicting or referencing criminal activity, this includes the use of keyword-based restrictions targeting terms associated with real-world crimes and individuals

Evidence & Analysis (cont.)

However, keyword filtering can be circumvented by users looking to create crime-related avatars, experiences and events. For example, while content referencing the Christchurch mosque shootings is restricted by keyword, a February 2026 report identified a Roblox experience titled “14” that recreated the attack, alongside user group affiliations referencing violence against civilians.

Current methods will also not address cross-platform dissemination of Roblox. For example, during this study we found on YouTube, tutorials demonstrating how to create Roblox avatars resembling Sean 'Diddy' Combs (Figure 6).

Cross-platform pollination of violent crime reenactments can pose a significant online safety problem when it feeds into communities and subcultures dedicated to harmful content or ideas. For example, the Roblox experience *Blood Debt*, has been associated with the so-called “True Crime Community” (TCC), characterised by interest in mass violence.

These findings raise the question of whether Roblox contributes to online cultures in which real-world violence is trivialised, normalised or sensationalised, and to what effect.

Implications for Australian Policymakers & Law Enforcement

This tech issue briefing presents four key questions for consideration by Australian regulators and policymakers:

1. **Scope of the Online Safety Act:** Does the Act adequately cover harms to young people that can arise through virtual world reenactments and interactions?
2. **Platform Accountability:** Are current content moderation approaches sufficient for enforcing stated rules?
3. **Parental Supervision:** Do parents and caregivers have meaningful insight into children’s experiences in virtual world environments?
4. **Research Gaps:** What are the psychological, social and developmental impacts of encountering real world violent and sexual crimes themed content and reenactments?

Further Reading

Gray, J. E., Carter, M., & Eglison, B. (2024). *Governing social virtual reality: Preparing for the content, conduct and design challenges of immersive social media*. Springer Nature Switzerland. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-61831-4>

Hindenburg Research (2024, October 8). *Roblox: Inflated Key Metrics For Wall Street And A Pedophile Hellscape For Kids*. https://hindenburgresearch.com/roblox/?utm_campaign=lawsuit-alleges-roblox-hosted-digital-diddy-freak-off-themed-games

About This Research

For further detail or to cite this research, please refer to the full report:

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